

The Dynamic Existential in Tagalog

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Abstract: This paper is focused on existential (and possessive) sentences in Tagalog that are constructed around a verbal existential verb (which I refer to as the *dynamic existential*). Although this verb appears to be an unaccusative verb in its use in existential sentences, I argue that it is actually a transitive verb equivalent to HAVE, with a covert external argument (which is overt in possessive sentences constructed from the same verb). In addition to providing a unification of the syntax of existential and possessive constructions, I argue that this analysis explains the morpho-syntax of dynamic existential constructions (relating, in particular, to the distribution of case) that would be otherwise mysterious if the existential verb were a true unaccusative. The proposed covert external argument in existential sentences funds precedent in ‘impersonal’ like constructions in other languages, and as I briefly discuss. I propose that this external argument (which is overt in possessive sentences) is an (implicit) locative, and discuss briefly some implications for unifying a prefix *ka-* that is found in the existential verb and subject experiencer verbs in the language (as discussed by Kaufman 2011, 2012). If the analysis proposed here is on the right track, it suggests that Tagalog falls at the lower end of a spectrum for availability of “expletive” external arguments (Icelandic being at the high end, Norwegian and English being somewhere in the middle).

Key terms: Existential, locative, possessive, expletives, Dependent Case Theory, Tagalog.

*Several examples throughout were pulled from the web or a personal corpus, but confirmed with native speakers for grammaticality. Other examples based on elicitation. The following glossing conventions are used throughout: (IM)PERF ‘imperfective’, CONT ‘contemplative’, REC.PERF ‘recent perfective’, INF ‘infinitive’, AT ‘Actor-topic’, TT ‘Theme-topic’, LK ‘linker’, UNM ‘unmarked’, DEP ‘dependent’, OBL ‘oblique’.

1 Introduction

This article is focussed on a construction in Tagalog that I will refer to throughout as the *Dynamic Existential*, which is exhibited by sentences like (1).

- (1) Nagkaroon ng phreatic eruption sa bulkang Mayon ngayong hapon.
PERF.EXIST_there DEP phreatic eruption LOC volcano.LK Mayon now.LK today
‘There was a phreatic eruption at Mayon volcano today.’
(web:URL – currently dead link)

In Section 2 of the paper, I present three arguments that the sole surfacing DP argument (=the E(xistential)C(lause)-Pivot) is an internal argument (=complement) of the dynamic existential predicate (*magkaroon*). This sets up the main analytical challenge posed by sentences like (1). Concretely, given the status of the EC-Pivot as an internal argument, the (dynamic) existential predicate appears to be an unaccusative verb. Unlike ordinary unaccusative verbs (see example (2)), however, whose sole argument surfaces as a SUBJECT case-marked DP, the sole argument of the (dynamic) existential verb surfaces as a non-SUBJECT case-marked argument in that it realizes the same morphological case that it is typical of internal arguments broadly construed to include both internal *external* arguments as well as (in-situ) verb complements (see Section 2 for details).

- (2) Dumating ang tren kanina.
PERF.COME UNM train a_while_ago
‘The train arrived a while ago.’
(English:421)

Following assumptions prominent in the recent literature, I will assume that SUBJECT case-marking on a DP (glossed as UNM(MARKED) in the examples) is not indicative of any specific Case-value, but instead is indicative of an Agree relationship that is established between this DP and a functional head of the clause (Guilfoyle, Hung and Travis 1992, Rackowski 2002, Aldridge 2004, 2012, Pearson 2005, Chen 2025, among others). SUBJECT case-marking of a DP, together with specific inflection on the verb, serve the function of “flagging” this Agree relationship (to use the term from Deal 2022). Given the absence of SUBJECT-case on the EC-Pivot, then, it stands to reason that this Agree relationship has failed to occur in existential sentences like (1). In Section 3, I consider two possible explanations for why this failure to Agree might arise: Either (i) because of the absence of structure containing the Probe for Agree; or (ii) a conflicting ‘topic’ feature required of the Probe and its Goal (=the EC-Pivot), the conflict being that Probe requires a Goal that is [+top] (Pearson 2005, Chen 2025), whereas the EC-Pivot must be [-top]. Neither of these explanations I shall argue provide a satisfactory account.

Section 4 of this paper offers my analysis of dynamic existential sentences and a solution to the problem posed above. It involves two key assumptions: First, I propose that existential sentences like (1) involve the projection of a covert DP (which I refer to as *pro_∃*) in Spec, vP. According to this analysis, in other words, the dynamic existential predicate

is not in fact an unaccusative predicate but rather is a transitive predicate – namely, the transitive predicate HAVE, which projects both an internal and an external argument. When coupled with a Dependent Case Theory approach to case (Marantz 2000, McFadden 2004, and recent references), the result to emerge is that the EC-Pivot is associated with accusative rather than nominative Case (or rather, in the terminology of the Dependent Case Theory approach, a DEP(endent) case rather than the UNM(arked) case). Following a proposal of Bobaljik (2008), I will adopt the view that agreement (here, stated in terms of the operation Agree) obtains between a functional element of the clause (e.g., T) and the DP that has been assigned the unmarked case. Applied to Tagalog, Agree holds between an inflectional head and the unmarked DP resulting in SUBJECT case-marking of a DP and the special verbal agreement on the verb. When a covert DP is projected, it is this DP that functions as a Goal for the purposes of Agree, but when an overt DP is present – as is the case of possessive sentences like (3), which are also formed using the predicate (*magkaroon*) as in existential sentences, it is the DP that expresses the possessor that is the Goal for Agree and which can (because of its overtness) be expressed with SUBJECT-case.

- (3) Bakit nagkakaroon ng cancer ang isang tao?
 why IMPERF.exist_there DEP cancer UNM a.LK person
 ‘Why does someone get cancer?’
 (<https://www.abs-cbn.com/news/health-science/2025/2/12/alamin-bakit-nagkakaroon-ng-cancer-ang-isang-tao-1842>)

In Section 5 of the paper, I will suggest that the hypothesis that the existential predicate projects a covert external argument flows rather naturally from related proposals of ‘impersonal’ like constructions in other languages, and the general proposal that the existential predicate is basically the transitive predicate HAVE (possession), which the existential predicate is also used to express (see, e.g., Freeze 1992, Kampanarou 2024, Hoekstra 1994). I will propose that the covert DP hypothesized to be projected in (non-possessive) existential sentences expresses an implicit location and that ‘possessive’ DPs in sentences like (3) are overt versions of this locative. Following recent work by Kaufman (2011, 2012), I offer some tentative remarks about the connection between the locative semantics of possessors in existential/possessives sentences formed on the basis of the dynamic existential predicate and subject experiencer verbs, which are formed in part using the morpheme *ka-*. If, subject experiencers are locations, as argued by Landau (2010), then a path is opened up for some degree of unifying the argument structure of the existential verb and subject experiencer verbs. Section 6 concludes the paper.

2 Argument Structure of the Dynamic Existential

Tagalog contrasts three cases, summarized below in (4).

(4) *Tagalog Case:*

	SUBJECT	INTERNAL-E. ARGUMENT/V	COMPLEMENT	OBLIQUE
NAME	<i>si</i>	<i>ni</i>		<i>kay</i>
COMMON N.	<i>ang</i>	<i>ng</i> (= [nang])		<i>sa</i>

As is fairly standard from the literature, I will not refer to these cases using terms like nominative/accusative or ergative/absolutive. Instead, when referencing these case particles I will generally refer to the syntactic function of the argument that is realized with a particular case marker. For instance, the SUBJECT-case will be reserved for the DP that assumes most (though not all) properties typically identified with subjects (see, e.g., Schachter 1976, Kroeger 1993, Rackowski 2002, Chen 2024, among others). In the examples below, it is marked by the case particle *ang* and controls agreement inflection on the verb (glossed as AT (=ACTOR-TOPIC) or TT (=THEME-TOPIC) in the examples throughout).¹ Crucial for us, the case marker *ng/ni* can realize case on a DP that is an internal argument (e.g., the theme) in so-called ‘Actor-topic’ sentences such as (5), or an *internal* external argument (e.g., the agent) in so-called ‘Theme-topic’ sentences such as in (6).

- (5) *Bumili* *ang* *lalaki* *ng* *bulaklak* *para sa* *nanay* *niya*.
 PERF.AT.buy UNM man DEP flower for OBL mother his
 ‘The man bought a flower for his mother.’

- (6) *Binili-Ø* *ng* *lalaki* *ang* *bulaklak* *para sa* *nanay* *niya*.
 PERF.buy-TT DEP man UNM flower for OBL mother his
 ‘The man bought the flower for this mother.’

Under the approach to the relationship between sentences like (5) and (6) developed in Rackowski (2002) (see also, Rackowski and Richards 2005), Rackowski proposes that the abstract Case associated with the core argument DPs is uniform: The agent has nominative Case, while the patient has been assigned accusative Case in both sentences. Neither the SUBJECT-case nor the *ng*-case therefore are morphological *realizations* of these abstract Case features. As discussed in more details below, the SUBJECT-case is the morphological case expressed on a DP that enters into an Agree relationship with T (or some similar functional head located above the vP; see also, e.g., Hung, Guilfoyle, and Travis 1992, Pearson 2005, Chen 2025). Crucially, this extends to the *ng*-case as well. In theory, *ng*-marking may realize abstract accusative Case as in (5) or nominative Case in (6). For convenience, and for reasons that will become clear in Section 4, I will gloss these cases as UNM (=unmarked) and DEP (=dependent) in the examples throughout.

Against this backdrop, the dynamic existential is of special interest. As noted above, the sole argument in this existential constructions (henceforth, the E(xistential) C(onstruction)-Pivot surfaces with *ng*-case (see example (1)). A few addition examples of this construction

¹This is not typical agreement for ϕ -features. Instead, it either reflects Case-agreement (Rackowski 2002, Pearson 2005) or θ -Agreement (Latrouite 1999). While nothing too crucial hinges on this, I will adopt the Case-agreement view here (see Section 2 (fn. 11) for further details).

are offered in (7).

- (7) a. Maaring walang isang punong dahilan kung bakit
 can.LK not.exist.LK one.LK single.LK reason COMP[+Q] why
 nagkakaroon ng Alzheimer's Disease.
 IMPERF.exist.there DEP Alzheimer's Disease
 'There isn't just one single reason why there is Alzheimer's Disease.'
 (<https://www.ritemed.com.ph/ano-ang-sanhi-ng-alzheimers-disease>)
- b. Nagkaroon ng system problem kaya hindi nalogout ng maayos
 PERF.exist.there DEP system problem so.that NEG PERF.log_out NANG properly
 nung last thursday.
 then.LK last thursday
 'There was a system problem last Thursday so I could not log out properly.'
 (<https://www.instagram.com/reel/DN1SOBPXFUS/>)

Given the proposals referenced above, the presence of *ng*-case marking on the theme argument of the existential predicate is consistent with this DP (henceforth, the EC-Pivot) being an external argument (specifically, an *internal* external argument) or a 'true' internal argument.² The former possibility seems initially unlikely given that external arguments tend thematically to correspond to an agents/experiencer θ -role (which the argument of the existential predicate is decidedly not), whereas the latter possibility raises a different set of theoretical implications for the analysis of Case/case in Tagalog, which can be summarized as follows.

If the EC-Pivot is an internal argument, this still does not resolve the question of what (abstract) Case value it might be associated with, since *ng*-marking could be the realization of a DP with a nominative or accusative Case value. If it is accusative, as I will ultimately argue, the dynamic existential plainly provides an argument that Burzio's Generalization (BG), stated in (8), is not a universal.

- (8) *Burzio's Generalization* (Burzio 1986: 178)
 All and only the verbs that can assign a θ -role to the subject can assign accusative Case to an object. [subject = external subject (agent)]

Issues for BG notwithstanding, dynamic existentials pose other analytical challenges as well. In particular, if the existential predicate is an unaccusative capable of assigning accusative Case, why are other unaccusative verbs in the language evidently unable to surface with a (*ng*-)case marked argument? The sole argument of an ordinary intransitive (and unac-

²I refer to the '*internal* external argument' to describe external arguments in 'Theme-topic' sentences for reasons discussed in references above. As Richards (2013) observes, for instance the external argument of 'Theme-topic' sentences behaves as though it is higher (in terms of c-command) than the internal argument of a verb for some purposes, but for other purposes, it is the 'promoted' internal argument that appears to be higher of the two arguments. I will therefore assume that an *internal* external argument resides in Spec, vP (or Spec, VoiceP) and in this sense is internal. See also Guilfoyle, Hung, and Travis 1992 for additional explicit discussion.

cusative) verb in Tagalog surfaces with SUBJECT-case marking (as was shown on the basis of example (2) above, for instance). Of course, this is only a problem in so far as existential sentences and sentences containing ordinary unaccusative verbs have the same argument/clause structure. This, arguably, is the null hypothesis, though one which I will overturn in Section 4, where I propose that the argument structure for the (dynamic) existential sentence contains a covertly projected DP and that the existential verb is therefore basically transitive.

In the remainder of this section, I will offer three arguments that the EC-Pivot of the dynamic existential predicate is a (true) internal argument (rather than an external argument). After this conclusion is established, I will move on in Section 3 to argue that existing analyses of Case assignment for Tagalog offer potential solutions to the absence of SUBJECT-case marking on the EC-Pivot (in terms of reduced clause structure or conflicting features), but that these solutions do not provide an adequate solution. In short, existential sentences have the same array of functional heads which serve as Probes for an Agree operation as sentences with ordinary unaccusative verbs have, and all other conditions that would yield the morpho-syntax of the surface structure of sentences with ordinary unaccusative verbs appear to be met. In Section 4, I propose that it is the argument structure of the dynamic existential predicate (=number of DPs that are syntactically projected) that differentiates existential sentences from those containing ordinary unaccusative verbs.

2.1 EC-Pivot as an Internal Argument

2.1.1 Uniformity With the Stative Existential

Alongside the dynamic existential predicate (*magkaroon*³), there is a stative existential predicate, *may(roon)*. The main difference relating to the chosen nomenclature for these predicates is that the former, but not the latter, can inflect for the primary aspects made available to the language ((IM)PERFECTIVE and CONTEMPLATIVE). Example (9) is another example of the dynamic existential, example (10) exemplifies the stative existential.

Dynamic Existential:

- (9) Muling magkakaroon ng isang hari na mamamahala sa isang malawak
 again.LK CONT.exist.there DEP a.LK King COMP CONT.rule LOC a.LK vast
 na lupain.
 LK land
 ‘There will again be a King who will rule over a vast land.’
 (<https://www.facebook.com/groups/bible7verses/posts/25030129399975431/>)

³This verb is morphologically complex, consisting of at least three elements: N+, *pagka-* (which I also take to be complex, consisting of two prefixes, *pag* and *ka-*), and a root *roon*. N+ is the nasal prefix that occurs in many ‘Actor-topic’ verbs formed with a prefix *pag-* or *pa-*. I will assume in this work that the nasal prefix is an allomorph of the infix *-um-* (see, e.g., Maclachlan 1998, Travis 2005, 2010, and Rackowski 2002 for details).

Stative Existential:

- (10) Mayroong iba pang karapatan, mga hindi kasama at mga espesyal na...
exist.there.LK other still.LK rights PL not friend and PL special COMP
'There are other rights, exclusions, and specials (that are not listed).'
- (<https://files.ontario.ca/employment-standards-in-ontario-tagalog.pdf>)

Important for some of the arguments to be made below, these existential predicates also appear in sentences expressing possession (broadly construed). Such sentences arise when a SUBJECT-marked DP argument is added to the structure. Consider the following example, illustrating a possessive with the dynamic existential predicate.

Possessive Dynamic Existential:

- (11) Nagkaroon ng bagong kahulugan ang 'ghosting'.
PERF.exist.there DEP new.LK meaning UNM 'ghosting'
'Ghosting' took on/had a new meaning.'
- (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?vhZTtkCPdNcw>)

Sabbagh (2009) argues that the the EC-Pivot in stative existential predicates is composed with its predicate via semantic incorporation, and utilizes Chung and Ladusaw's (2004) semantic composition rule *Restrict* to formalize this analysis.⁴ Semantic incorporation has been the subject of much recent research (see, in particular, van Geenhoven 1998, Farkas and de Swart 2003, Chung and Ladusaw 2004, Dayal 2011, Lopez 2012, Massam 2013, Barrie and Li 2015, Sağ, Demirok and Bal 2025). In brief, semantic incorporation is a process in which a property denoting DP (or sub-part of DP, e.g., NP) is conjoined with the property denotation of a predicate (e.g., an existential verb) to form a complex predicate. When a verb's complement is semantically incorporated, it does not saturate an open variable associated with the predicate but rather forms a restriction on that predicate, as schematized in (12) (for a VP such as *read a book*).

- (12)
- $$\begin{array}{c} \text{VP} \\ \lambda y \lambda x. \text{read}'(x) \wedge \text{book}'(x) \\ \swarrow \quad \searrow \\ \text{V} \quad \text{DP} \\ \lambda y \lambda x. \text{read}'(y)(x) \quad \lambda x. \text{book}'(x) \end{array}$$

Although semantic incorporation could, in theory, incorporate an external argument (see, e.g., Sağ, Demirok and Bal 2025 on agent-incorporation), the robust cross-linguistic pattern is that it is internal arguments that are overwhelmingly the prototypical target of

⁴See Sabbagh 2009:708-712 for formal details, including a discussion of why it is possible that for the EC-Pivot to be realized without morphological case and why a 'linker' appears attached to the existential predicate *mayroon*).

syntactic and/or semantic incorporation. As semantic incorporation is often viewed as the semantic effect of syntactic incorporation (broadly construed to include instances of what Massam (2001) describes as pseudo-incorporation), the fact that syntactic incorporation is likewise generally restricted to internal arguments (Mithun 1986, Baker 1988, 1998, Barrie and Mathieu 2016, among others) comes as no surprise.

Now, if the EC-Pivot is semantically incorporated in stative existentials as argued for in Sabbagh (2009), and if the stative and the dynamic existential project their argument structure in a uniform way, then it follows that the EC-Pivot is uniformly projected as an internal argument rather than an external argument in both stative and dynamic existential sentences. This conclusion can be further reinforced by considering a version of the dynamic existential that appears to involve (true) syntactic incorporation. In the above examples of the dynamic existential, the predicate *magkaroon* appears with a case-marked DP (=the EC-Pivot). In examples like the following, we see what appears to be the (dynamic) existential predicate minus the root element *roon*. When the predicate surfaces as such, it appears prefixed to the EC-Pivot which is no longer case-marked. Consider the following examples.

- (13) a. Ngunit, totoo bang **nagkaka**-_[NP ulcer] ba dahil sa stress?
 but true Q.LK exist- ulcer Q because OBL stress
 ‘But, is it true that there are ulcers caused by stress?’
 (<https://hellodoctor.com.ph/fil/kalusugan-sa-digestive/peptic-ulcer-disease/nagkaka-ulcer-ba-dahil-sa-stress/>)
- b. Alamin kung **magkaka**-_[NP COVID-19 surge] ulit.
 find.out- if CONT.exist- COVID-19 surge again
 ‘Find out if there will be another COVID-19 surge.’
 (<https://upd.edu.ph/events/stop-covid-deaths-are-there-more-contagious-variants-like-omicron-xe-alam-in-kung-magkaka-covid-19-surge-ulit/>)
- c. **Nagkaka**-_[NP interes sa pagsasaka] sa Bicol region.
 IMPERF.exist- interest OBL farming LOC Bicol region
 ‘There are interests in farming in the Bicol region.’
 (<https://www.bomboradyo.com/mga-nagkaka-interes-sa-pagsasaka-sa-bicol-dumarami>,
modified)
- (14) a. ***Nagka**-_[isang/ilang gera] sa Europe noon.
 PERF.exist.there- a.LK/some.LK war LOC war then
 (‘There was a war/some war(s) in Europe then.’)
- b. ***Nagkaka**-_[mga interes sa pagsasaka] sa Bikol region.
 PERF.exist.there- PL interest OBL farming LOC Bikol region
 (‘There’s some interests in farming in the Bikol region.’)

Sabbagh (2009:680-682) argues that the EC-Pivot in examples like this is a reduced nominal argument – an NP rather than a full DP. He observes, for instance, that the nominal argument is phrasal in that it may be modified by an AP or co-occur with a noun complements (see 13b,c). On the other hand, the nominal argument in such examples cannot, as illustrated by the ungrammaticality of (14a) above, support (indefinite) quantifiers (e.g., *isa* ‘a, one’,

ilan ‘some’) or even the plural marker *mga* (see 14b). Given this, examples like those in (13) appear to involve a construction akin to what Massam (2001) refers to as pseudo-Noun-Incorporation (PNI). PNI is only ‘pseudo’, however, in that it does not involve morphological concatenation of a nominal root with a verbal root (forming a V+N compound), in the sense of Mithun (1986) and Baker (1988). It is, on the other hand, genuine syntactic incorporation in the sense that an argument is expressed in some non-canonical, structurally reduced way.

Relevant for us, this type of incorporation is unavailable for any argument other than the EC-Pivot. For instance, the EC-Pivot may be incorporated in a possessive sentence, but a possessor may not. The contrast between (15) and (16) makes this clear.

- (15) Bakit **nagkaka**-[_{NP} *singaw at sugat*] ang bibig?
 why IMPERF.exist- fumes and sore] UNM mouth
 ‘Why does the mouth have (bad smelling) fumes and sores?’
 (<https://www.tiktok.com/@docwillieong/video/7260770142769007873?lang=en>)
- (16) *Bakit **nagkaka**-[_{NP} *bibig*] (ng) *singaw at sugot*?
 why IMPERF.exist- mouth DEP fume and sore
 (‘Why is there mouth-having (of) (bad smelling) fumes and sores?’)

The contrast here strongly suggests two things: (i) The possessor DP, when present, is syntactically an external argument; and (ii) The EC-Pivot is an internal argument. The following subsections offer two more arguments yielding the same conclusion.

2.1.2 The Specificity and Definiteness Effect

Sabbagh (2009:690-682) observes that there is a definiteness effect with respect to the EC-Pivot in stative existential sentences. Cross-linguistically, this definiteness effect is quite common (Milsark 1979, McNally 1997, 2009, Chung and Ladusaw 2004, Dobrovine-Sorin and Beyssade 2012, among others). It is perhaps not very surprising, then, to observe that a definiteness effect arises in dynamic existential sentences as well, as the following (ungrammatical) sentences illustrate.

- (17) a. *Nagkakaroon ng lalaking iyon sa harap ng bahay ko.
 PERF.exist.there DEP man.LK that LOC front DEP house my
 (There was that man in front of my house.)
- b. *Nagkaroon ng bawa’t babae sa tindahan.
 PERF.exist.there DEP each woman LOC store
 (There was each/every woman at the store)
- c. *Nagkaroon ni Juan sa party.
 PERF.exist.there DEP Juan LOC party
 (There was John at the party)

As discussed in Section 2.1.1, Sabbagh (2009) proposes that the existential predicate in Tagalog is composed with its complement via the non-saturating compositional rule *Restrict*, as proposed by Chung and Ladusaw (2004). Since *Restrict* works by composing

properties (i.e., elements with the semantic type $\langle e, t \rangle$), it generally follows that the EC-Pivot must denote a property of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ as well. Thus, DPs modified by a demonstrative or restricted by a quantifier (as in 17a, b) as well as proper name DPs (as in 17c) will not be able to compose with the existential predicate (as these, we may assume, are not of the type $\langle e, t \rangle$).⁵

In the context of the definiteness effect for existential sentences, it is relevant to note that Tagalog has repeatedly been claimed to exhibit a *specificity effect* for internal arguments in so-called ‘Actor-topic’ sentences (Manaster-Ramer 1988, Richards 2000, Rackowski 2002, Aldridge 2004; cf. Sabbagh 2016, Paul et. al. 2015, Collins 2019). For instance, the object (theme) argument in (18) unless explicitly marked for specificity most naturally gives rise to a non-specific interpretation.⁶

- (18) Bumili ng libro ang babae.
 PERF.AT.buy DEP book UNM woman
 ‘The woman bought a book/#the book.’

Formal analyses of this particular specificity restriction have taken at least two paths. The first approach builds on Diesing’s (1992) *Mapping Hypothesis* as the source of the effect (see, e.g., Rackowski 2002, Aldridge 2004, 2012). Specifically, assuming that the verb’s internal argument in (18) resides in VP, and that VP (or vP) represents the domain of existential closure, the object must denote a property that includes a variable that can be existentially bound.⁷

- (19)
- $$\begin{array}{c}
 \text{VP} \\
 \exists y \exists x. \text{read}'(y)([\text{book}(x)]) \\
 \lambda y \lambda x. \text{read}'(y)([\text{book}(x)]) \\
 \swarrow \quad \searrow \\
 \text{V} \qquad \text{DP} \\
 \lambda y \lambda x. \text{read}'(y)(x) \quad \lambda x. \text{book}'(x)
 \end{array}$$

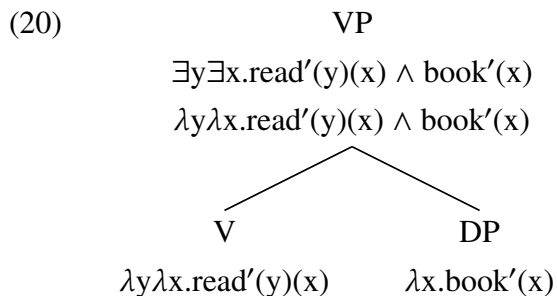
In more recent work, the idea has been put forward that the specificity effect in (18) might reflect the general availability of semantic incorporation of a verb’s internal argu-

⁵Sabbagh’s analysis is a bit more complex, as it involves also the assumption that the existential predicate has a subcategorization requirement that requires its complement to be property-denoting (cf. McNally 1997). Overall, it is not crucial for the argument made in the main text whether this is the correct approach to the definiteness effect. Instead, the observation that is important is that it or something like it (i.e., a separate specificity restriction) restricts internal arguments only. I mention particular approaches here because they tend to be formulated to account for just this property.

⁶Sabbagh 2016 argues unmarked objects are assigned an unmarked non-specific interpretation, but that objects may be marked for specificity, and – hence – specific DPs are not necessarily excluded from functioning as objects.

⁷Diesing 1992, following Heim 1982, assumes that indefinite denote simple one-place predicates whose variable is (unselectively) bound, rather than assuming that they denote generalized quantifiers.

ment in Tagalog. Starr (2015) (see also Barrie and Sung 2020) proposes, for instance, that (unmodified) *ng*-marked objects can compose with a verb via Chung and Ladusaw’s *Restrict*, mentioned earlier. Under this proposal, the composition of (18) precedes somewhat differently, as shown in (20) (repeated from (12) above), but the effect is the same regarding the basic account of the definiteness/specificity effect in so far as any complement that does not denote a property of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ will not be able to compose in such a manner as to derive the final logical forms given.



Crucial for our purposes, whichever of these approach (or some alternative) is taken to these definiteness/specificity effects, the effect itself appears to target internal arguments only. This is corroborated by the Tagalog facts. An external argument is never subject to a definiteness/specificity effect. This is especially true when the external argument is marked with *SUBJECT*-case, but also when it is not externalized as in a ‘Theme-topic’ sentence like (21) (see Paul et. al. 2015, Sabbagh 2016, and Collins 2019 for more detailed investigation). More concretely, internal arguments that are unadorned (e.g., by specific markers of definiteness/specificity) are understood as indefinite/non-specific, but an internal *external* argument is ambiguous with respect to this feature. This point is made by comparing (18) above with sentence (21).

- (21) *Binili-Ø ng babae ang libro.*
 PERF.buy-TT DEP woman UNM book
 ‘Some/the woman bought a book.’

If definiteness/specificity effects in Tagalog only arise for internal arguments, then the natural conclusion reached here concerning existential sentences is that the EC-Pivot is an internal argument and not an external argument. Relevantly, when a possessor DP is included along with the existential predicate and the EC-Pivot, it is not subject to a definiteness/specificity effect. This is clear in example (22), as well as examples (23) where the verb is marked for the *Recent Perfective* aspect. Sentences that include a verb that is inflected for recent perfective aspect, like existential sentences, lack a *SUBJECT*-marked DP (see Section 3.1 for more on this construction). Example (23) illustrates (compare to example 22).

- (22) *Nagkakaroon ang babae ng anak ngayon.*
 IMPERF.buy UNM woman DEP child now
 ‘The/(??a) woman has a child now.’

- (23) Kapagkaroon lang ng bababe ng internet.
 RECE.PERF.exist.there just DEP woman DEP internet
 ‘The/(??a) woman just got the internet.’

Crucially, even in the recent perfective aspect where the external argument is not SUBJECT-marked, it may be definite/specific.⁸ I conclude, therefore, that the definiteness/specificity effect only ever holds of a verb’s internal argument and never for external arguments. Given the definiteness effect associated with the EC-Pivot in (dynamic) existential sentences, we can also therefore conclude that it is an internal argument and not an external argument.

2.1.3 Adjunct Control

In Tagalog, an adjunct clause may contain a missing argument as long as the missing argument is understood as controlled by an argument of the main clause. Consider example (24).

- (24) N-agpinta si Juan₁ ng isang larawan [upang mapabilib PRO₁
 PERF.AT-paint UNM Juan DEP a.LK picture in_order INF.TT.ABIL.impress PRO₁
 ang kanyang ina].
 UNM his.LK mother.
 ‘Juan painted a picture in order to impress his mother.’

In (24), PRO corresponds to the agent argument of the verb contained in the adjunct clause, and is bound to the SUBJECT/agent of the main clause. PRO may also be bound by a non-SUBJECT external argument, as illustrated in (25).

- (25) Ninakaw-an ni Juan₁ ang isang bangko [upang mapakain PRO₁ ang
 PERF.rob-TT DEP Juan UNM a.LK bank in_order INF.TT.ABIL.feed his.LK
 kanyang pamilya].
 family
 ‘Juan robbed a bank in order to feed his family.’

Crucially, an internal argument cannot control PRO within an adjunct clause. Consider example (26). PRO within the adjunct clause must correspond to the agent argument of the main clause, *Manny*. This is true even though it is easy to imagine that it was the (painting of) the spider that actually scared the fly.

- (26) Nagpinta ng gagamba₁ si Manny₂ [para takut-in PRO_{*1/2} ang
 PERF.AT.paint DEP spider UNM Manny in_order INF.scare-TT UNM
 langaw].
 fly
 ‘Manny painted a spider in order for him (=Manny) to scare a fly.’

⁸Some speakers with whom I consulted were unsure if an indefinite/non-specific interpretation was available. See Guilfoyle, Hung, and Travis 1992 and, more recently, Collins 2021.

Note that the facts here hold regardless of whether the agent (e.g., Manny) is the SUBJECT of the main clause or an internal external-argument. The fact remains that PRO is understood as referring to the external argument/agent of the main clause and cannot be understood as referring to the internal argument – even if this is the SUBJECT of the main clause as in (27).

- (27) I-*pininta* ni Manny₁ ang gagamba₂ [para takut-in PRO_{1/*2} ang
 TT-PERF.pain DEP Manny UNM spider in_order INF.scare-TT UNM
 isang langaw].
 a.LK fly
 ‘Manny painted the spider in order for him (=Manny) to scare the fly.’

Given this observation, note next that the EC-Pivot of a dynamic existential may not be the controller of PRO inside an adjunct clause. Example (28) makes this point rather clearly. To the extent that it is an interpretable sentence at all, it only has an interpretation where PRO is either PRO_{arb} (=arbitrary pro) or refers to the speaker. PRO cannot refer to the spider.

- (28) Nagkaroon ng gagamba₁ sa dingding [para takut-in PRO_{*1/arb/spk}
 PERF.exist_there DEP spider LOC wall in_order INF.scare-TT
 ang isang langaw].
 UNM a.LK fly
 ‘There was a spider on the wall in order scare a fly.’

Given the generalization established by (24)-(27) – that PRO may only be controlled by an external argument of the main clause – the fact reported by the example in (28) confirms the conclusion that the EC-Pivot is an internal argument and not an external argument.⁹

3 Explaining the Absence of SUBJECT

In this section, we explore a couple of possible ways of understanding the distribution of Case in dynamic existentials within the context of existing analyses of the assignment of Case in Tagalog. We show that none of these existing analyses provides a means to shed light on the dynamic existential, thus calling for a novel approach.

In recent decades, many proposals have been put forward concerning the assignment of Case to DPs in Tagalog. What each of the proposals to be reviewed here have in common is the assumption that Case is assigned via the mechanisms of Agree (Chomsky 2000, 2001 et. seq.). What most analyses additionally have in common is that the Case assigned to an external argument is distinct from that which is assigned to a VP-internal argument.

⁹I have focussed here more on the requirements of the controller rather than the controllee, PRO. This is due to the fact that Tagalog does allow for null arguments (pro-drop) for DPs in a variety of syntactic positions but also restricted by a variety of factors (see, e.g. Himmelmann 1999, Nagaya 2006). More to the point, there may be examples that appear to involve controlled PRO that is not an external argument even when this PRO would be controlled by an external argument. I have therefore left consideration of such examples out of the discussion and focus just on the restrictions associated with the controller for PRO, which seems robust.

Rackowski (2002), for instance, proposes that *v* is the source for accusative Case assigned to an internal argument (=theme), whereas *T* is the source of nominative Case assigned to the external argument (=agent/experiencer). For Pearson (2005), who develops an analysis of Malagasy which has a similar type of ‘symmetric voice’ alignment system as Tagalog, nominative Case is assigned to the external argument by an Event-head, *E*, which resides below *T* but above *vP*, and accusative Case is assigned to an internal argument by an Asp-head, *Asp*, which is folded into *vP*.¹⁰ Finally, Chen (2025) proposes that nominative Case is assigned by a Voice-head, *Voice*, to the external argument and that *v* assigns accusative Case to any VP-internal argument. These various proposals, including the one by Aldridge (2004, 2012) who analyzes Tagalog as an ergative-absolutive language, are summarized in (29). (Note, I use the subscript θ on *v* to indicate that – as far as I can tell – the proposals that have *v* assigning accusative Case pertain also only to *v* that assigns an external θ -role, in resonance with BG.)

(29) *Assignment of Case in Tagalog:*

	NOMINATIVE	ACCUSATIVE
Rackowski (2002):	<i>T</i>	<i>v_θ</i>
Pearson (2005):	<i>E(event)</i>	<i>Asp(ect)</i>
Chen (2025):	<i>Voice</i>	<i>v_θ</i>
	ERGATIVE	ABSOLUTIVE
Aldridge (2004, 2012):	<i>v_θ</i>	<i>T</i>

Although the first three approaches share a view that Tagalog has a nominative-accusative alignment, Chen 2025 specifically remarks that nominative-accusative alignment is obscured by the fact that the actual morphological marker of case can also be viewed from the perspective that the language has an ergative-absolutive alignment (De Guzman 1988, Aldridge 2004, 2012). The reason for this, as previously noted, is that the morphological markers of case do not perfectly align with the abstract Case-value associated with a DP. Consider, for instance, the analysis of the case markers *ng/ni*. For the authors cited above, this case marker is not the spell out of a particular Case-value. It could be the spell out of an accusative Case feature on a DP assigned by *v/Asp* as in (30), but it could also be the spell out for the nominative Case feature assigned by *T/E/Voice* if and when it surfaces on the external argument as in an example like (31).

- (30) *Bumili* *si Juan* *ng magazin* *sa tindahan*.
PERF.buy.AT UNM Juan DEP magazine LOC store

¹⁰Although Pearson’s analysis is developed for Malagasy, it is suggested in Pearson (2005) and by others that the analysis could be extended to other languages such as Tagalog which exhibit a “Philippine like” Case alignment system. On this type of system, see Himmelman 2005, and Chen 2025.

- (31) Binili- $\emptyset$ ni Juan ang magazin sa tindahan.
 PERF.buy-TT DEP Juan UNM magazine LOC store

Based on the same set of examples, we can see that the SUBJECT-case is not the spell out of a particular Case-value. In (30), it marks a DP which has been assigned nominative Case, while in (31), it is the spell out of case for a DP that has been assigned accusative Case. Crucially for the works cited above (and assumed here) this case marking is unique because its purpose is to “flag” (to use a term from Deal 2022) a special relationship with a functional head higher up in the clause with which this DP Agrees. Concretely, according to Rackowski (2002) (see also Richards and Rackowski 2005), T is not only responsible for assigning nominative Case, it is also the functional head that must enter into an Agree relationship with the closest DP in its c-command domain. It is this DP which will surface with the SUBJECT-case, and which is also reflected by the special agreement inflection on the verb.¹¹

Thus, if a verb’s complement undergoes a process of Object Shift, moving it higher than the external argument, then – even though valued accusative for Case – the actual case marker will be spelled-out as SUBJECT-case and the external argument DP which is assigned nominative Case will be marked with the case marker *ng/ni*. Chen (2025) (similarly to Pearson 2005) proposes that T bears a [priv] feature that must be checked/Agree with a DP carrying the same feature. Morphologically, this Agree relationship is “flagged” by the case marker *ang/si* (and verbal inflection), regardless of the actual Case-value that has been assigned to this DP.¹²

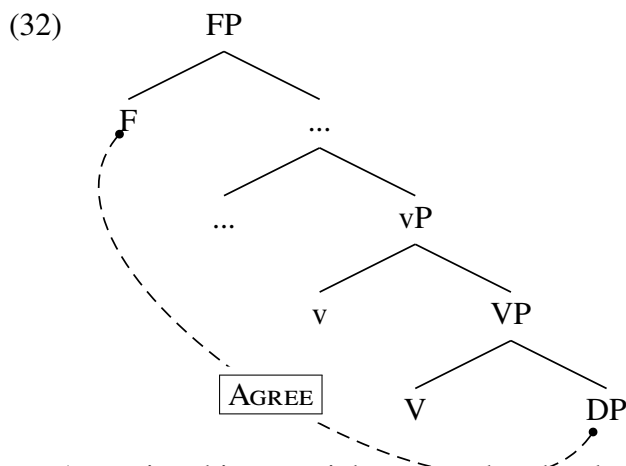
Given these proposals, one could imagine a clause type in Tagalog in which all DPs have been assigned Case, but which lack a DP specifically marked by the SUBJECT-case. Such a clause type might arise if T (or some other relevant functional head) does not Agree with any DP in the clause, thus leaving all DPs “unflagged” by the SUBJECT-case. Sentences where the verb are inflected for *Recent Perfective* are one plausible scenario where this might occur, which I will discuss below. First, though, considering this possibility more generally for now we can consider how it might account for the difference between existential sentences constructed around the unaccusative *magkaroon* and the derivation for ordinary

¹¹For the purposes of this work, I will assume, following Rackowski (2002) and others, that the relevant agreement involves Case-agreement. Specifically, Agree(ment) between a functional head such as T and the Case-value of the structurally most prominent DP in T’s c-command domain. In terms of exponence of this agreement, the following realizations rules will suffice:

- (i) a. AGR $\leftrightarrow$ -in / [Acc, Inf/Contemplative]
 b. $\leftrightarrow$ $\emptyset$ / [Acc]
 c. $\leftrightarrow$ N+/-um- / [Nom, Inf/+begun]

¹²In this way, Chen and Rackowski’s analyses are very similar. More precisely, Chen proposes that the actual Case value (Nom or Acc) of the [priv] DP is ‘overwritten’ by the form that realized as *ang/si*, which is not a Case per se, but something more akin to a Topic-marker. She does not, however, provide a formal implementation of this idea of Case over-writing through something like a set of realization rules for the spell-out of Case-features.

unaccusatives (as in example (2) above). In the ordinary course of events, in addition to the assignment of Case to single DP argument, there should also be an Agree relationship between some head (simply referred to as F below) with the sole DP argument of the verb. This Agree relationship will “flagged” by the SUBJECT-case (and reflected by the special agreement on the verb). This is illustrated in (32).



Assuming this, we might reason that the absence of SUBJECT-case on the DP argument (=EC-Pivot) of existential sentences could be the result of a failed Agree relationship between DP and this functional head, leaving the Case of the DP (whether nominative or accusative) to be expressed morphologically as *ng/ni*.

Failure of the Agree relationship illustrated in (32) might come about from two sources: Either (i) The head that potentially Agrees with the DP – i.e. F – is absent from the structure; or (ii) Some feature that F probes is incompatible with some feature(s) of DP (or vice-versa), thus leading to a failed Agree.¹³ I consider these possibilities in the following two subsections, arguing that neither is sufficiently motivated by the facts and therefore does not provide a solution to the main analytical problem.

3.1 Absence of Structure

As mentioned above, Chen argues that SUBJECT-case marked DPs are so marked because they have entered into an Agree relationship with a functional head that bares a [PIV] feature.¹⁴ This [PIV]-feature, according to Chen, is compatible with DPs that essentially function as ‘topics’, “featuring definiteness/specificity and conveying old information”. She further assumes that this topic marker is obligatory in “all finite clauses with a CP layer that licenses topics”. For Chen, then, the most natural explanation for existential sentences (i.e., for the absence of a DP marked with the SUBJECT-case) would be the absence of a CP layer

¹³I assume, with Preminger 2014 (in particular, Preminger 2014:Chapter 5), that failed Agree does not necessarily result in ungrammaticality, contra Chomsky 2000, 2001.

¹⁴For Chen, this head is C, though I will represent it as F below so as to more easily discuss other proposals that differ in this detail (specifically, with respect to the identity of the functional head that it involved in Agree) but not in overall approach.

to license such a topic (assuming it is a functional head within this domain that Agrees). This approach is essentially the approach that Hsieh (2025) takes for explaining the absence of a topic marker in clauses where a verb is inflected for *Recent Perfective* aspect, as in (33).

- (33) Kabibili lang ng lalaki ng magazin.
 REC.PERF.buy just DEP man DEP magazine
 ‘The man just bought a magazine.’

According to Hsieh (2025:547-551), the absence of a SUBJECT case-marker on a DP in recent perfective sentences such as (33) reflects the absence of an inflectional head, I/T, which encodes aspect but is also (presumably) responsible for probing the structure for a DP to Agree with (either an external/highest DP argument within vP or, in the absence of an external argument, to the sole DP argument of an intransitive predicate). For the existential sentences under discussion, it cannot be the lack of this element (F, in the tree in (32)) that is responsible for the absence of the SUBJECT case-marker. The existential predicate in dynamic existential sentences are distinguished from their stative counterparts (as in examples like 10) precisely because they occur in one of the various core aspects available to Tagalog: PERFECTIVE, IMPERFECTIVE, CONTEMPLATE, and even RECENT PERFECTIVE. If, as Hsieh contends, the presence of aspect entails the presence of an Agree head for a DP, then it follows that this Agree head is present in the structure of the dynamic existential.

Relatedly, sentences with recent perfective aspect cannot be negated, according to Hsieh (2025:548).

- (34) *Hindi lang kainom ng guro ng kape.
 NOT only REC.PERF.drink DEP teacher DEP coffee
 Intended: ‘It’s not the case that the teacher had just drunk coffee.’
 (Hsieh 2025:548)

Hsieh appears to take the lack of an I/T to also entail the lack of a suitable location for negation.¹⁵ Crucially, then, we observe that dynamic existential sentences may be negated, as illustrated by the grammaticality of examples like (35). Therefore, the relevant pieces of the structure encoding aspect and negation must be present in existential sentences formed with the predicate *magkaroon* in contrast to recent perfective sentences, which are syntactically reduced according to Hsieh’s proposal for them.

- (35) a. Hindi nagkaroon ng digmaan hanggang sa ikatatlumpu’t-limang
 NEG PERF.exist.there DEP war until OBL thirty_five.LK
 taon ng paghahari ni Asa.
 year DEP rule DEP Asa
 ‘There wasn’t a war until the 35th year or Asa’s rule.’

¹⁵Hsieh (2025) does not explicitly say why the recent perfective is incompatible negation. His implicit explanation for the incompatibility with negation seems to be, however, that the entire standard inflectional domain of the clause, which consists of at least IP and VoiceP, and which would also *presumably* include NegP, is replaced with a projection of a functional head, Tel(icity).

- b. para sigurado na hindi nagkakaroon ng hawahan sa
 in_order certain C[-Q] NEG IMPERF.exist.there DEP contamination LOC
 loob ng bahay.
 inside DEP house
 'to ensure that there is no contamination inside the house.'

If it is not the absence of a functional layer containing carrying Aspect (and room for negation), then the possibility that remains is that existential sentences lack a head in the CP (A')-domain. This approach would be one that flows from systems like Chen's as well as Pearson's (2005) proposal which expands the CP-domain into a whP subordinated to a TopP. Differences in details aside, the absence of SUBJECT-case could arise if this CP-layer is not present in the syntax of (dynamic) existential constructions according to these proposals because the functional head that Agrees with a DP resulting in SUBJET-case (e.g., C) is found in this domain. This cannot be the solution to the problem either, however. Supposing that FP in the illustrations represent this CP-layer, as the examples below make clear, dynamic existentials may be embedded. When they are, they are introduced by an appropriate complementizer (*kung* for C[Q], *na* otherwise).

- (36) Hindi ko alam [kung [nagkaroon ng ganito sa Pinas noon]]
 not 1SG.DEP know C[Q] exists.there DEP something LOC Philippines then
 pero mukhang masarap s'ya.
 but look.1k delicious 3SG.UNM
 'I don't know if there was something like this in the Philippines before but it looks delicious.'
- (37) Sinabi ni COMELEC Chairman George Erwin Garcia [na [nagkaroon ng
 said DEP COMELEC Chairman Geroge Erwin Garcia C[-Q] exist.there DEP
 pagbabago sa mga nominado ng TINGOG Party-list]].
 change DEP pl nomination DEP TINGOG Party-list
 'COMELEC Chairman G.E.G. said that there was a change in the nominations for the party list.'

Note furthermore that the EC-Pivot may be questioned.

- (38) a. Ilang digmaan ang nagkaroon noon?
 some.LK war C[WH] PERF.exist.there then
 'How many wars were there back then?'
- b. Anong kalseng problema ang magkakaroon kapag nagbalik
 what.LK class.LK problem C[WH] CONT.exist.there when PERF.ATreturn
 ako sa bahay?
 1SG.UNM LOC house
 'What kind of problems will there be when I get home?'

Other phrases, besides the EC-Pivot, may be questioned as well.

- (39) a. Alam niyo ba [kung [kailan nagkaroon ng maganda sa mundo]]?
 know 2SG.DEF Q C[Q] when PERF.exist.there DEP beautiful LOC world
 ‘Do you know when there was something beautiful in the world?’
 (<https://www.wattpad.com/amp/68076613>)
- b. Bakit nagkakaroon ng bula sa aquarium?
 why IMPERF.exist.there DEP bubble LOC aquarium
 ‘Why are there bubbles (forming) in the aquarium?’
 (<https://www.tiktok.com/@jerrysantos2879/video/7404006829165989138>)

Assuming that interrogatives involve movement of an operator into a CP-domain, the fact that examples like (38)-(39) are grammatical militates against attributing the lack of such a domain as an explanation for the lack of an SUBJECT case-marked DP in (dynamic) existential sentences.

A final reason to reject the idea that the absence of an SUBJECT-case marked DP is correlated with the absence of structure – in particular, the absence of a functional head to Agree with a (Case assigned) DP argument – comes from the existential construction itself when used to express possession. When so used, there is an additional DP corresponding to a possessor which surfaces with SUBJECT-case, as illustrated here with example (40).

- (40) Pagkatapos, nagkaroon si Absalom ng karwahe at mga kabayo, at
 after PERF.exist.there UNM Absalom DEP chariot and PL horse and
 nakapagtipon siya ng 50 personal na tagapagbantay.
 PERF.ABIL.gather 3SG.UNM DEP 50 personal LK guard
 ‘After that, Absalom had a chariot and horses and was able to gather 50 personal guards.’

Assuming that the minimal difference between an example like (40) and non-possessive existential sentences like those we have seen throughout relates to the presence of an (overt) external argument in the former but not the latter, it stands to reason that this DP (=the external argument) can enter into an Agree relationship with whatever functional head leads to SUBJECT case-marking. In other words, the head that probes a DP resulting in (Goal) “flagging” with SUBJECT-case is present and active when the vP is formed around the dynamic existential predicate. Assuming that the number of arguments within the vP does not dictate the presence/absence of functional structure above vP, it follows that this Agreeing head must be present in ‘true’ existential sentences lacking an external argument.

3.2 A Conflicting Topic-Feature?

Since it is not the absence of structure that is responsible for the lack of SUBJECT-case marking in existential sentences, another explanation must be sought out. One potential avenue to explore here is the proposal put forward by Chen (2025), but pre-figured in much earlier work on the language, according to which the SUBJECT case-marked DP must be associ-

ated with a discourse status of ‘topic’. For instance, Rackowski (2002) (see also Richards 2000) states that the SUBJECT case-marked DP must be specific (similar, for example, to objects in Germanic which undergo Object Shift). Pearson (2005) echoes this idea by stating that the selection of an argument as the SUBJECT case-marked DP is based on what DP the speaker “wishes to assign greatest referential prominence, the argument of which the rest of the clause is predicated.” Although this broad analysis appears to be adopted by Chen (2025) as well, Chen does leave an exact definition of topic open, noting in passing that it is challenging to define topic in a way that is suitable from language to language (Chen 2025:1884-1889).¹⁶ However, in regards to this issue we may consider the work of López (2009) in his work on the role of information structure from a derivation perspective of syntax. In this work, López (2009, in particular, Chapter 2) articulates a view of topic as a feature [+a] ([a]=anaphoric) associated with an XP. In brief, a topic/DP with a [+a]-feature must be linked to a discourse antecedent (usually, a local one; in a subordinated rather than coordinate discourse). The topic and its antecedent do not have to be co-referential with one another. Instead, it is minimally sufficient that the antecedent be what the discourse is *about*, and that the topic be relevant or otherwise anchored to it.¹⁷ Note that under this conception of what a topic is, it is also not necessary that the topic be specific/definite – it may, for instance, introduce new discourse referents as is the function of many uses of indefinites. As evidence of this latter point, López cites the fact that a Clitic Right-Dislocated DP may correspond to an existential predicate’s sole argument in Catalan.¹⁸

- (41) a. Q: ¿Has comprat mobles?
 have.you buy furniture
 ‘Did you buy furniture?’
 b. A: N’hi han, de cadires.
 Yes, have of chairs
 ‘There are chairs.’
 (López 2009: 33-34)

As López demonstrates in his work, DPs that are right dislocated (by Clitic Right-Dislocation) must be topics/[+a], specifically, they must be anaphorically linked to what the discourse is about. Crucially, under this conception of the notion of topic, a topic may be at once a topic and still introduce a new discourse referent. The EC-Pivot of an existential sentence in Tagalog may be a topic in one or both of these senses. Consider first, for instance, the dialogue in (42).

¹⁶Kroeger (1993:Ch. 3) concludes that while the SUBJECT case-marked DP has some properties identified with topics, specificity requirements alone do not justify identifying a given phrase with topic status.

¹⁷See also Rizzi 2006:122, who proposes that subjects and topics both feature a [+about] feature, but that topics also carry a [+D-linking] feature (Pesetsky 1987, Cinque 1990). The notion of D-linking does not seem to be far removed from López [+a]-feature, in as much as it is consistent with the introduction of new discourse referents, as long as they are familiar or anchored to what the discourse is about.

¹⁸Though he does not provide examples, the mere fact that he discusses existential sentences here suggests that they are present new discourse referents. However, the status of the definiteness effect for Catalan has been shown to be at least weaker than English. See McNally (2009) for examples and discussion.

- (42) a. Q: Ano ang mga sintomas ng varicose veins?
 what UNM PL symptoms DEP varicose veins
 ‘What are the symptoms of varicose veins?’
 b. A: Isang pananakit o pananakit sa iyong mga binti o iba pang lugar
 a.LK aching or pain LOC your PL leg or other still.LK area
 kung saan nagkakaroon ng varicose veins.
 COMP[WH] where IMPERF.there.is DEP varicose veins
 ‘An aching or pain in your leg where varicose veins occur.’

In (42b), varicose veins is very clearly related to a discourse antecedent in the preceding question (42a) – even though the varicose veins under discussion are not co-referential (and, furthermore, the varicose veins referred to in A’s reply is not plainly specific/definite). The example in (43) offers another example. Here, the antecedent denotes a superset to which the EC-Pivot is linked, thus satisfying the simple aboutness requirement for the topic feature [+a].

- (43) a. Q: Anong kaganapan ang nangyari dito?
 what.LK event COMP PERF.happen here
 ‘What event happened here?’
 b. A: Dito ay nagkaroon ng “bachelor party”.
 here INV PERF.exist.there DEP bachelor party
 ‘There was a bachelor party here.’

Based on the examples discussed here, I conclude that there is no inherent incompatibility between the topic-feature associated with a Tagalog SUBJECT and the pivot of a (dynamic) existential sentence. In other words, if we view topic from the perspective of López’s [+a]-feature, nothing in principle should be wrong with a sentence of the form in (44), where the EC-Pivot is marked with the SUBJECT-case form.¹⁹

- (44) *Nagkaroon ang “bachelor party” dito.
 PERF.exist.there UNM bachelor party here
 ‘There was a bachelor party here.’

In the next section, I provide an analysis for why (44) is ungrammatical compared to its grammatical counterpart with *ng* case-marking for the EC-Pivot.

¹⁹Of course, there may be alternative conceptions of topic to the one that López puts forward which would have the result of a conflicting feature. However, in the absence of a specific counter-proposal, I will stick with López’s approach for the purposes of the argument.

4 Analysis of Dynamic Existentials

4.1 Case and Agree(ment) in Dynamic Existential Sentences

The arguments from Section 2-3 yielded two important conclusions concerning dynamic existential sentences: First, the EC-Pivot is a case-marked internal argument of the dynamic existential predicate (*magkaroon*); Second, the structure of the clause containing the dynamic existential predicate contains whatever functional element occurs in ordinary verbal clauses that functions as a Probe for Agree resulting in Goal “flagging” (i.e., a SUBJECT case-marked DP). As such, the fact that dynamic existential sentences are SUBJECT-less still requires an analysis that can help to explain this.

The first piece of my analysis involves a claim that, despite having the superficial appearance of being an intransitive/unaccusative verb, the (dynamic) existential predicate is actually a transitive verb. More concretely, it is a verb that expresses the transitive relation of HAVE. This proposal is already partially paid for given the observation that the predicate *magkaroon* serves as the predicate for sentences expressing possession, such as the sentence in (45).

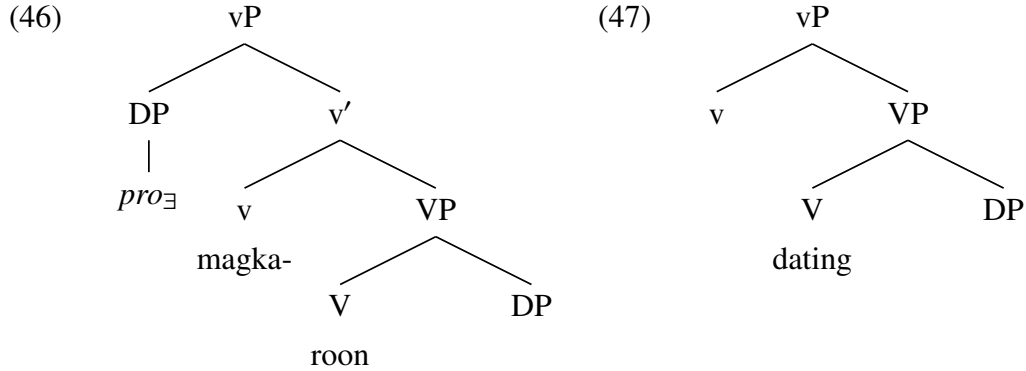
- (45) Magkakaroon ng bagong hitsura ang Department of Consumer Affairs
CONT.have_there DEP new.LK look UNM Department of Consumer Affairs
(DCA) ng California sa 2023.
DEP California LOC 2023
‘Californias DCA will have a new look in 2023.’
(https://www.dca.ca.gov/logo/index_tl.shtml)

The proposal to treat *magkaroon* as expressing the transitive relation of HAVE is supported by Kaufman (2011, 2012), who explores the multi-functionality of the affix *ka-* across several Austronesian languages. He ultimately concludes that Proto-Austronesian (PAN) **ka-* was an existential/possessive prefix which he transliterates as HAVE’, and describes this element as: (i) Not a full lexical verb but rather a functional element that signals that one argument is in the possession of another argument; and (ii) A universal atom of meaning which combines with other lexical and functional material to form complex predicates. Throughout history, PAN **ka-* retained this possessive use, Kaufman suggests, but expanded into other domains as well (e.g., experiencer predicates, accidental and abilitative predicates). Thus, the *ka-* that is observed with the dynamic existential predicate *Nag-ka-roon* is the retention in the modern language of this PAN possessive **ka-*.

Supposing this is correct, that *ka-* (combined with *pag*-²⁰), I propose that in (dynamic) existential sentences that the ‘possessor’ argument is present but non-overt — namely, that it is a *pro* (*pro*_∃, henceforth) that is roughly equivalent to the expletive locative *there* of existential sentences in languages like English (see below for more detailed discussion). To spell this out in more concrete terms, my hypothesis is that the dynamic existential verb is

²⁰The prefix *pag-*, following Maclachlan 1998, Travis 2000, 2005, and Rackowski 2002 is taken here to also be associated with the head that introduces the external argument.

associated with the vP structure in (46), whereas a ‘true’ unaccusative verb such as *dating* (‘to arrive’) is associated with a vP structure such as (47), which does not have an external argument projected in vP’s specifier.

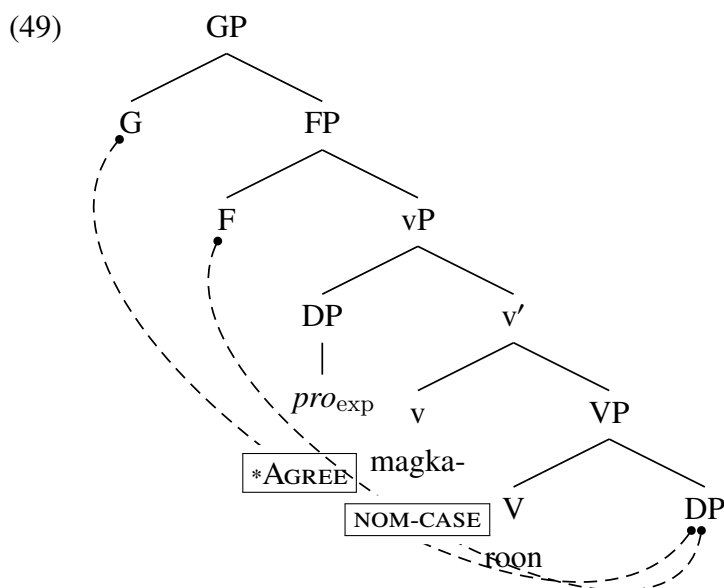


Supposing this difference, we will also continue to assume that SUBJECT-case marking is a “flag” for an Agree relationship established between a DP and some functional head above vP. As we have already established, this Agree relationship is independent of Case: Agree takes place with the structurally highest DP whether this DP has been previously assigned nominative or accusative (or oblique Case). Given this, it follows that the the EC-Pivot in dynamic existential structure in (46) does not take part in this Agree relationship, while the sole argument of an unaccusative does (since the former does not surface with SUBJECT-case, while the latter does). Two questions arise now. One question concerns case – concretely, what case is assigned to the EC-Pivot? A second question concerns the operation of Agree – concretely, if Agree applies to the internal argument of an unaccusative (with the V complement in a structure like (47)), what does it apply to in existential sentences given that it does not apply to EC-Pivot (otherwise, the EC-Pivot would be realized with SUBJECT-case)?

Let us consider first the question of case assigned to the EC-Pivot. As stated earlier, the specific realization of case (as *ng*-case) could in theory be the realization of either nominative or accusative Case. The idea that the EC-Pivot is assigned nominative Case arguably leads to a more complicated analysis, for the following reasons. Nominative Case, as proposed in the references cited earlier is assumed to be assigned (or valued) by a functional head that is external to vP (e.g., T/Ev/Voice), whereas accusative Case is generally assumed to be assigned internal to the vP – e.g., by v. If the EC-Pivot is assigned nominative Case, then we would necessarily have to assume that v in a structure like (46) is unable to assign accusative Case. If we assume that the *pro*_∃ which is hypothesized in (46) is semantically vacuous and does not have a theta-role associated with it, then failure of v to assign accusative case to the EC-Pivot arguably follows from Burzio’s Generalization, stated in (48).

- (48) *Burzio’s Generalization* (Burzio 1986: 178)
 All and only the verbs that can assign a θ -role to the subject can assign accusative Case to an object. [subject = external argument]

Ultimately, I will suggest (see section 5.1-5.2) that the hypothesized $pro_{\exists}$ is not semantically vacuous, but assuming for the sake of argument for now for that it is, this would set up the conditions for assignment of nominative Case to the EC-Pivot by a functional head that is external to the vP. Now, if it is nominative Case that is assigned to the EC-Pivot, and assuming that Case is assigned by the operation of Agree, then an immediate problem arises. Concretely, given these assumptions, nominative Case can be assigned to the EC-Pivot – skipping over the $pro_{\exists}$ that is merged in vP’s specifier – but the Agree operation that is responsible for Goal “flagging” of this DP evidently cannot. This scenario is illustrated in (49) (with G representing the (possibility distinct from F) head that Agrees with DP).



The problem for this approach is determining why the EC-Pivot should be available for Agree involving the assignment of Case, but not for the Agree resulting in “flagging” the DP as the SUBJECT. This is a particularly serious problem if one adopts the view of Rackowski (2002) (see also, Pearson 2005, Rackowski and Richards 2005, and Chen 2025) that Agree with the SUBJECT is, itself, Case-agreement (i.e., Agree within the Case-feature assigned to the DP which is to be flagged as the SUBJECT, as briefly discussed in fn. 11). For Rackowski (2002), in particular, since it is the same head (namely, T) that assigns nominative Case under Agree that also probes for the closest DP for Case-agreement, it seems implausible that a DP assigned Case by a functional head should not also be able to enter into a Case-agreement relationship with it. The problem, as far as I can tell, does not go away if we suppose that there are two separate heads, F and G, one responsible for assignment of Case (by Agree) and another responsible for Case-agreement. As Case is the relevant feature involved in both of these Agree operations, it remains unclear why one should be able to occur while the other is blocked.²¹

²¹Here, a number of possibilities could be proposed that involve tweaking or proposing various features. I do not articulate these possibilities here since, as far as I have been able to determine, most proposals that can be concocted have no generality beyond the express purpose of accounting for the problem at hand.

To shed light on this problem, one might appeal to the presence of the hypothesized covert DP as a *intervener* for the process of Case-agreement that results in Goal “flagging” (i.e., realization of SUBJECT-case), resulting in a situation akin to *Defective Intervention* (Chomsky 2000). Defective intervention is the term used to refer to situations, such as those well-documented in Icelandic, where subject-verb agreement is blocked when the subject is valued with a Case other than nominative, leading to ‘default agreement’ (i.e. a finite form that does not actually match the ϕ -features of any nominal argument). The following example, from Holmberg and Hróarsdóttir 2003:1000) illustrates (see also Bobaljik 2008, Preminger 2014:Chapter 7 and references therein).

- (50) það finnst/*finnas **einhverjum stúdent** tölurnar ljótar.
 EXPL find.SG/*find.PL some student.SG.DAT computer.the.PL.NOM ugly
 ‘Some student finds the computers ugly.’
 (Holmberg and Hróarsdóttir 2003:1000)

The connection with examples of defective intervention is, however, rather tenuous. In the scenario of defective intervention, the Agree relationship that is ‘blocked’ involves ϕ -features, specially a Probe searching for a DP it can value ϕ -features from. What blocks this agreement is something that arguably has ϕ -features as well, but which acts as an intervener because of the value it has for Case (dative, rather than nominative). According to the analysis of Bobaljik (2008), defective intervention obtains because the probe that is actively seeking ϕ -features to value from a DP may only probe a DP with nominative or *unmarked* case in the sense of Marantz’s Dependent Case Theory (on which, see Section 4.2 below). Put in different terms, Agree(ment) in languages like Icelandic is “Case discriminating”. Because it is Case discriminating, it selects only DPs with certain Case values to Agree with. If Tagalog agreement does not involve ϕ -features but instead involve Case-agreement, as the authors cited above have proposed, then this Agree(ment) plainly cannot be said to be Case discriminating. If it were, furthermore, it would not be so in a way that prevents Agree(ment) with a nominative Case marked DP. As Bobaljik’s and Preminger’s proposals make clear, if agreement can be with only one Case-value in a nominative-accusative language, it will be with the nominative (or rather, with the unmarked case in their terms). I conclude for these reasons that the EC-Pivot is not assigned nominative Case.²² If the EC-Pivot is assigned accusative Case, on the other hand, we get closer to an explanation for the absence of a SUBJECT in dynamic existential sentences, as proposed in the next subsection.

²²Possibly, if the Agreement that leads to Goal “flagging” of a DP with SUBJECT-case morphology does not involve Case agreement, then one might be able to develop a reasonably suitable story that is more aligned with the idea that there is defective intervention. One such possibility is that the Agreement involves θ -agreement (Latrouite 2011, 2018; Ramos 1974). While I am open to the view that the agreement involves θ -agreement (contra the views of many others), I will not pursue it at this time as it is not clear exactly what additional assumptions would be needed to solve the problem that is the current topic of this section.

4.2 EC-Pivot as Accusative/Dependent Case

Having rejected the idea that the EC-Pivot is associated with nominative Case, this leaves only one possibility – namely, that it is assigned accusative Case. To develop this proposal, I adopt the Dependent Case Theory (DCT) approach articulated in Marantz (2000) (see also Laka 2000, McFadden 2004, Baker and Vinakurova 2010, Baker 2015 and references cited therein). According to DCT, case is a purely morphological phenomenon rather than an abstract feature that a DP requires in order to be ‘licensed’. Case, or rather m(orphological)-case (hereafter, Case_m), may be, but is not necessarily assigned by functional heads such as T/v/etc. I will leave this question open and simply assume for now that case is assigned within a specified domain (e.g., vP) based on other structural properties of that domain – specifically, the presence of other DPs (aka case ‘competitors’) within that domain. DCT recognizes three cases: Unmarked, dependent, and lexical. In a nominative-accusative language, accusative is the dependent Case_m ([DEP]) and nominative is the unmarked ([UNM]). These two Cases_m are assigned according to the rule in (51).

(51) *Dependent Case:*

- a. If DP₁ c-commands DP₂ in vP, then assign DEP-case to DP₂
 - b. If DP₁ does not c-command another DP₂ within vP, DP₁ is unmarked.
- (Marantz 2000, McFadden 2004, Baker and Vinakurova 2010, Baker 2015)

Looking back at the structures in (46) and (47), we can now see how the different DPs will be case marked for the EC-Pivot in (46) compared to the sole argument of an ordinary unaccusative verb in (47). Concretely, since there is a DP (=pro_∃) projected in the vP for the existential predicate in (46), the EC-Pivot – being c-commanded by this DP – will be assigned dependent Case_m (i.e., accusative Case_m). Pro_∃ will be assigned unmarked Case_m, but since this DP has no phonological content it will not (we may reasonably assume) be able to host a realization of the any form of Case_m. In the structure in (47), on the other hand, there is only one DP within the vP (=the unaccusative verb’s theme). Since there is no case competitor (no DP projected in vP’s specifier), this DP will be assigned the unmarked case. As for the actual realizations for unmarked and dependent case, nothing much new needs to be added here beyond assumptions we have already made. We may continue to assume, in particular, that an operation of Agree takes place between a Probe (such as T) and the highest DP within vP, which will be the unmarked DP according to the rule in (51). This Agree relation is “flagged” by the realization of SUBJECT-case on the DP assigned unmarked case, as well as the particulars of the inflection on the verb. Returning to an earlier question – what does Agree apply to in existential sentences? – we can suppose that Agree takes place it is between T and the pro_∃. Since this DP is phonologically null, we can safely assume that no Case_m will be morphologically realized on it.²³ We can assume, however, that the inflectional on the verb serves as a different kind of “flagging” to show that this

²³If an additional DP is present, e.g., denoting a possessor, this DP of course will realized the SUBJECT-case.

Agree relationship has taken place.²⁴

5 The Nature and Content of *Pro*_∃ in Dynamic Existential Sentences

5.1 Covert *Pro* In Other Languages

At first blush, the proposal that existential sentences involve a projected *pro*_∃ vP specifier may seem to be a fairly bald proposal. We should note, however, that this proposal not without ample precedent from the literature. Null pronouns have been proposed in other languages for ‘impersonal’-type constructions that are related (in some cases, rather directly) to the dynamic existential in Tagalog. To reference a few works, Perlmutter and Moore (2002) propose that impersonal constructions like (52) in Russian, formed with an unaccusative/passive verb and a genitive theme contain a phonologically null DP subject akin to the English expletive *there* (see also Polinsky and Potsdam 2013).

- (52) V prudu ne plavalo kuvšinok.
in pond NEG floated.NEUT water_lilies.GEN
‘There weren’t any water lilies floating in the pond.’
(Perlmutter and Moore 2002, Polinsky and Potsdam 2013)

Wood (2017) proposes an expletive subject-like element for the syntax of ‘Accusative Subject Constructions’ (ASCs) like (53) in Icelandic, in which an unaccusative verb’s theme argument is realized as an accusative that occupies the subject position of the clause otherwise ordinarily occupied by a nominative subject.

- (53) Snjóa lysti.
snow.ACC melted
‘The snow melted.’
(Ottósson 1989:44, cited in Wood 2017:250)

Wood’s motivation for proposing a null expletive DP in the syntax of (53) is part of the inspiration for the proposal made here for the Tagalog dynamic existential. Concretely, he proposes the presence of an expletive DP in ASCs like (53) in conjunction with a Dependent Case analysis of accusative case in order to explain the presence of accusative case marking on the theme in the *apparent* absence of transitivity/an (overt) ‘case competitor’ (i.e., a nominative subject). The presence of the covert expletive DP, a clitic projected in Spec, VoiceP according to Wood (2017:265), provides the case competitor for the unaccusative

²⁴See footnote 11 on this inflection. A question I leave open here is whether *pro*_∃ is ‘active’ for Agree, or whether Agree results in failed/default agreement. Plainly, the nasal prefix (N+) indicative of agreement is present on the existential predicate, though this could arguably be the default agreement form. Nothing crucial hangs on this issue, as far as I can determine.

verb's internal argument, thus allowing this argument to be assigned dependent case given a rule like the Dependent Case rule stated above.

Even closer to home, Kampanarou (2024) discusses Greek existential sentence formed around the predicate *exi*. Like (*may/magka-*)*roon* in Tagalog, this predicate in Greek serves as the basis of simple existential sentences as in (54), but can also express the possessive relation in the presence of a nominative subject as in sentences such as (55).

- (54) Exi ena vivilo eki pera.
 have.3SG a.ACC book.ACC there over
 'There is a book over there.'
 (Kampanarou 2024:16-22).
- (55) I Maria exi amaksi.
 the.SG.NOM Mary.NOM have.3SG car.SG.ACC
 'Mary has a car.'
 (Kampanarou 2024:5)

Kampanarou's analysis of (54) and (55) also serves as inspiration for the analysis of dynamic existentials presented above. Concretely, Kampanarou argues that *exi* in (54) and (55) involve the projection of two DPs within the thematic domain (vP/VoiceP), but that in the existential sentence (54) one of these two DPs (namely, the external argument) is a covert DP expletive. The most important consequence of this analysis comes in how it helps to explain the presence of accusative case on the theme argument. In conjunction with a Dependent Case approach for Greek case (see also Anagnostopoulou and Sevaldi 2021), the presence of an external argument (whether null, as in (54), or overt as in (55)) provides the case competitor which allows for the assignment of accusative case to the internal argument.

5.2 *Pro_{un}*

In recent work, Collins (2024) has also proposed that a covert *pro* is projected in English in short passives (see also Angelopolous et. al. 2023 and Müller 2019). He in fact proposes that UG makes three types of *pro*: *pro_{gen}* (a generic third person human); *pro_{un}* (a featureless *pro* that is existentially bound, by existential closure); and *pro_{def}* (a referential, non-generic pronoun).²⁵ *Pro_{un}* is the covert argument projected in a short passive like (56a) under the interpretation that there was someone who killed John.

- (56) a. John was killed.
 b. [TP [VoiceP *pro_{un}* [Voice killed [DP John]]]]

The covert DP that I have proposed may be taken as related to Collins' *pro_{un}*, except that I would like to propose here for Tagalog that this *pro_{un}* can be animate or inanimate, and that it is associated with a locative semantics – i.e., it expresses a (possibly unspecified) location.

²⁵See also, Landau 2010, Borer 1998, Sichel 2024.

Under this conception of things, a ‘possessor’ is a (type of) location, which can be animate as in (57a) or inanimate as in (57b).

- (57) a. [T]ila kinuwestiyon kung nagkaroon ba raw ng daga sa dibdib
seems INF.question-TT C[Q] PERF.exist.there Q PART DEP rat LOC chest
si Duterte.
UNM Duterte
‘It seems he was asked whether Duterte had a rat in his chest.’
(<https://balita.mb.com.ph/2025/12/04/bat-biglang-dinaga-si-polong-rep-tinio-binoldyak-pagtanggi-ni-rep-duterte-sa-ici/>)
- b. Nagkaroon ng technical glitch Miyerkoles ang online app na
PERF.exist.there DEP technical glitch Wednesday UNM online app LK
EZConsult...
EZConsult
‘The EZConsult app had a glitch on Wednesday...’
(<https://www.abs-cbn.com/news/05/06/21/vaccine-scheduling-app-ezconsult-nagkaroon-ng-glitch-mga-user-nagkalituhan>)

The idea of ‘possessor’ is most thoroughly explored by Clark (1978) (see also, Freeze 1992, Harley 1995). Perhaps the only novel claim made here is the claim that there is a null *pro_{un}* that is the covert counterpart of the overt DP that expresses a ‘possessor’ in examples like (57). From a semantic point of view, this does not seem to be a terribly bald claim. Concretely, it simply amounts to the proposal that a sentence like (58) (repeated from earlier), can be taken to express a HAVE-relation, in other words a more literal translation as: *some location_{prox}* had a party at/in it.

- (58) Dito ay nagkaroon ng “bachelor party”.
here INV PERF.exist.there DEP bachelor party
‘There was a bachelor party here.’

Possible independent support for the claim that the dynamic existential verb licenses a *pro_{un}* with locative semantics derives from an observation made by Kaufman (2011, 2012). He notes, in particular, that in addition to its presence in the existential verb, the prefix *ka-* is observed in the form of many subject experiencer verbs – specifically, in the ‘Theme-topic’ form of such verbs. Examples of some subject experiencer verbs are given in (59).

	ROOT	ACT-TOPIC	TH-TOPIC	
(59)	galit	ma-galit	ka-galit-an	‘be angry’
	hiya’	ma-hiya’	i-ka-hiya’	‘be ashamed’
	limot	lumimot	ka-limut-an	‘forget’
	takot	ma-takot	ka-takut-an	‘be afraid’

If, as argued by Landau (2010) (see also Arad 1998), it is true that experiencers (of sub-

ject experiencer verbs) are locations, then we may in principle be able to unify the role of *ka-* for the dynamic existential verb and (at least some) subject experiencer verbs. Concretely, we may suppose that *ka-* is a (partial) realization of *v* and that it carries a requirement for a specifier, which we can express via a feature [**•D•**] (to use the notation introduced by Heck and Müller 2007). In addition to requiring a DP specifier, we can assume that this specifier must be associated with a locative interpretation.

We are now in a position to summarize the proposal, by briefly discussing how it accounts for the ungrammaticality of an existential sentence like (60) (repeated from earlier), with SUBJECT-case on the EC-Pivot, and a sentence like (61) in which the subject of an unaccusative verb surfaces with *ng*-case rather than SUBJECT-case marking.

- (60) *Nagkaroon ang “bachelor party” dito.
 PERF.exist.there UNM bachelor party here
 ‘There was a bachelor party here.’

- (61) *Dumating dito ng tren.
 PERF.come here DEP train
 (‘The train came here.’)

Sentence (60) is ruled out according to the analysis because the EC-Pivot is assigned dependent Case_m according to the rule in (51a). Following the spirit of the proposal made in Bobaljik (2008), where it is proposed that ϕ -agreement targets the DP with unmarked Case_m, we can say for Tagalog that Goal “flagging”, which results in the realization of SUBJECT-case on a DP and concomitant agreement inflection on the verb, targets the DP that is assigned unmarked Case_m as well.²⁶ Given that it will be the DP in vP’s specifier (= *pro*_∃/*pro*_{un}) that is assigned the unmarked Case_m, Agree must take place with this DP rather than the EC-Pivot. As *pro*_∃ lacks phonological content, it does not host any actual realization of the SUBJECT-case that would be expressed on an overt DP.

Sentence (61) is ruled out for the following reasons. As there is only a single DP within vP with an unaccusative verb such as *dating*, this DP (=the internal argument of the unaccusative verb) is assigned the unmarked Case_m according to the DCT case assignment rule in (51) (specifically, by (51b)). Since it receives the unmarked Case_m, it is eligible for Agree with the functional head that results in Goal “flagging” a DP with SUBJECT-case and concomitant agreement realized by the inflectional morphology of the verb. In short, (61) is ungrammatical because the case form realized on the DP is not the correct one, as spelled out by the realization rules in (62) (note, for convenience I use K as the head projected over a nominal (DP) as the head that realizes case).

- (62) a. K[oblique] ↔ *sa/kay*
 b. K[αcase] ↔ *ang/si* / Agree(T, ____)
 c. K[αcase] ↔ *ng/ni* / elsewhere

²⁶In other words, the only departure from Bobaljik 2008 resides in the fact that agreement on the verb in Tagalog does not involve ϕ -features, but rather something like Case-features.

5.3 Final Remarks

The analysis of the dynamic existential compared to ordinary unaccusative verbs involved mainly the claim that the former, but not the latter, has a projected external argument (in the form of the hypothesized $pro_{\exists}/pro_{un}$. If this proposal is on the right track, then we can additionally suppose the existence of (at least) two different types of v : v_{LOC} and v_{cause} . Suppose, as above, that v_{LOC} requires DP to merge as its specifier, but assume – by contrast – that v_{cause} may, but need not, merge with a DP specifier. If v_{cause} does not merge with a specifier, we get an (ordinary) unaccusative verb structure in (63a). If v_{cause} does merge with a DP specifier, we get a transitive verb as shown in (63b).²⁷

- (63) a. $[_{VP} [_{V'} v_{cause} [_{VP} V DP]]]$
 b. $[_{VP} DP [_{V'} v_{cause} [_{VP} V DP]]]$

The idea that v_{cause} is included in the structure of unaccusatives as well as transitives is not crucial here, but I note in passing that it allows for a simple account for now for the observed productivity of a intransitive/lexical causative alternation in the language (McClaghlan 1998, Travis 2000, 2005). This alternation is exemplified by the forms in (64), from Travis (2005:175).²⁸

- (64) *tumumba* ‘X fall down’ *m+pag+tumba* ‘Y knock X down’
sumabog ‘X explode’ *m+pag+sabog* ‘Y scatter X’
um-akyat ‘X climb’ *m-pag-akyat* ‘X bring up X’

The transitive forms here involve the prefix *pag-*, which we might take to be the morphological realization of v_{CAUSE} containing a $[\bullet D \bullet]$ -feature (otherwise, when v_{cause} does not merge with a specifier as in the case of the intransitive alternate, it is spelled out as $\emptyset$). Now, since v_{cause} in the intransitive does not select for a DP specifier, it follows that pro_{un} cannot be merged here. By hypothesis, pro_{un} also cannot merge as the specifier of v_{cause} in (63b) since the $[+loc]$ feature associated with it is, we may reasonably assume, not compatible with the semantics associated with v_{cause} (i.e., assuming that locations never function as agents or causers).

To place this proposal in a broader cross-linguistic perspective, we can observe that it amounts to the claim that there is one major difference between Tagalog, on the one hand, and languages such as English on the other hand when it comes to the availability of an “expletive” such as $pro_{\exists}/pro_{un}$. Assuming that the English expletive *there* is roughly equivalent to this element in English, we can observe that in English it has a wider distribution than what we find for Tagalog. Concretely, as is well known, English expletive *there*

²⁷I have not fully considered whether there should be a projection of Voice in addition to vP . Omission of VoiceP from the structure should be viewed only as a simplifying measure for ease of presentation, not as taking a position on its role in the expression of argument structure.

²⁸On causative with intransitives, see Levin and Rappaport Hovav 1995, Kalluli 2007, Koontz-Garboden 2009, and Alexiadou, Anagnostopoulou, and Schäfer 2015.

can function as the subject of sentences containing unaccusative verbs belonging to specific sub-classes such as (certain) verbs of appearance, verbs of occurrence, verbs of substance emission (Levin 1993:237, 258, 260), among other verb sub-classes discussed in Levin (1993). Following Deal (2009), the (sub-)class of verbs that allow expletive subjects can be distinguished from those that do not (namely, all inchoatives) given the hypothesis that the former group subcategorize for *there*, whereas the later group subcategorize for something else (for Deal, this something else is a CAUSE argument). Speaking somewhat informally, we might infer from the discussion of Tagalog that there is an implicational relationship among verb classes with respect to the availability of *there*-like subjects (whether overt or covert). Concretely, a language may permit such subjects only for an existential/possessive verb or it may permit them for existential/possessive verbs as well as the sub-classes of verbs (Category II) that include those mentioned above. Including change of state intransitives and transitives to this, we have the hierarchy in (65).

- (65) TRANSITIVE/CAUSATIVE > INTRANSITIVE/CHANGE OF STATE (CATEGORY I) > INTRANSITIVE (CATEGORY II) > EXISTENTIAL/POSSESSIVE

At the high-end of the scale we find languages like Icelandic which allow for Transitive Expletive Constructions (TECs) and also appears to have expletive subjects available with all intransitive verbs (Holmberg and Platzack 1995, Vikner 1995). Next, there are languages like Norwegian that lack TECs, but appear to permit them with all types of intransitive verbs (Hetsvik 1986). English allows expletive constructions with Category II intransitives and in existential constructions (Deal 2009), but not with transitives or Category I intransitives. Finally, if the proposal of this paper is on the right track, then Tagalog finds itself at the low end of the hierarchy, allowing an “expletive” with the existential/possessive predicate, but not with any other verb type. Reasons of space preclude a full investigation of the various analyses of expletive constructions and an explanation for the hierarchy in (65). For our purposes, I mainly wish to show that if something like (65) is correct, then based on the analysis put forward here, Tagalog completes a descriptive picture relating to a possible implicational universal surrounding the availability of “expletives” with respect to various verb sub-classes.

6 Conclusion

I have argued in this paper that the *dynamic* existential verb, though it appears to be an unaccusative verb, is actually a transitive verb that expresses the transitive HAVE relation. The external ‘possessive’ argument of this verb is overt in ‘possessive’ sentences, but – by hypothesis – covert ($=pro_{\exists}$) in the context of ‘existential’ sentences. In both contexts, I have suggested that this argument refers to a location (hence, possessors in possessive sentences are locations). When coupled with a Dependent Case Theory, the surface morphosyntax of dynamic existential sentences becomes easily contrasted with that of ‘ordinary’ unaccusative verbs, whose sole argument always surfaces as a SUBJECT-case marked argument

in contrast to the EC-Pivot, which surfaces without case (in stative existential sentences) or with *ng*-case marking in dynamic existential sentences. As I hope to have shown, the various pieces of the analysis put forward here have been independently motivated for ‘impersonal’ (or impersonal-like) constructions in other languages. It was finally (though, tentatively) suggested that the availability of impersonal clause structure (in particular, the availability of expletive/locative subjects) may be restricted by verb class according to an implicational hierarchy, with languages like Icelandic representing the most wide-spread distribution, and Tagalog representing the most restricted distribution.

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